contemporaries in every other state of India's Union. With more than half a million Indian troops and paramilitary police based in the Vale of Kashmir by 1975, that state looked more like an occupied territory than part of a free country. Every fine hotel in Srinagar was usurped by the Indian army to house and feed its officers, as were the best houseboats on Dal Lake. Most of India's troops in Kashmir were Hindus from the south or from remote regions of the land who understood neither the Kashmiri language nor the Islamic faith, and many of whom had never before met any Muslims. Major crossroads of Srinagar were blocked by sandbag towers erected in their centers with anxious soldiers inside, peering out from behind automatic weapons at even more anxious pedestrians and slow-moving traffic. Hardly a day passed without some incident that led to either the arrest or shooting deaths of young Kashmiris, who bravely shouted or innocently laughed at seeing those soldiers trembling behind their deadly weapons.

Indira Gandhi's choice for Kashmir's governor was a Hindu named Jagmohan, an autocratic sycophant who bought off enough of Dr. Farooq Abdullah's supporters in Kashmir's Assembly to undermine Farooq's elected position as chief minister of the state, triggering vocal popular opposition, which was violently repressed by Jagmohan's "black cat" Border Security guards. Lion of Kashmir Sheikh Abdullah's son Farooq was later returned to his rightful position as chief minister by Indira's son Rajiv after he inherited his mother's power in 1986. By then, however, Farooq's bravest young followers were completely alienated from him and from India, hating Jagmohan's repression and Indira Gandhi's duplicity.

The battle cry of young Kashmiris became "Azaadi!" ("Freedom!"). Had that not, after all, been the noble cry throughout India in the last decades of the British Raj? And was it not the cry that finally forced Prime Minister Gandhi herself to give up the ill-advised repression of her Emergency Raj after two years of locking up innocent opponents? Was it not the very cry suddenly sweeping the world, this cry for freedom, liberation, human rights? Why should Kashmir alone be excluded from this universal dream?

When fresh elections were held in Kashmir in 1987, a coalition of Farooq Abdullah's National Conference Party and Rajiv Gandhi's Congress Party won a clear majority in the state Assembly. "If I want to implement programmes to fight poverty, and run a government, I will have to stay on the right side of the center," the realist Farooq explained